
**Unit 1, Option C,
Topic C3: The Slave
Trade, Slavery and
the Anti-slavery
Campaigns, c1760-
1833**

The focus of this topic is on the rise and growth of the slave trade, the economic and cultural impact of this trade for the British Empire and the movements that brought about the abolition of slavery in the Empire in 1833. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of the operation and fall of slavery within the British Empire and the challenges this posed to economic and social forces in the period. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on the opposition to slavery would draw on elements of bullet points 1, 2 and 3 to explain and expand on the moral arguments of the campaigners.

The first bullet point relates to the reasons for, and growing extent of, British involvement in the slave trade. This involves an understanding of the Atlantic economy of the mid-18th century, including the transportation of slaves to the West Indies and southern plantation states in British North America, and the return to Britain with cargoes of sugar, tobacco and cotton. The significance of this for the British economy should be understood.

The second bullet point relates to the structure and operation of slavery in British colonies, including the nature of transportation to the colonies, the role of the plantation, life for slaves in the colonies and the importance of family.

The third bullet point relates to the anti-slavery campaigns. Students should be aware of the range of support for abolition, the arguments used and the nature of the campaigns. This could be illustrated by reference to the contribution of religious groups (the Quakers and the Evangelical movement, in particular the Clapham Sect) and the work of individuals (Thomas Clarkson, Olaudah Equiano, John Newton, William Wilberforce, and Thomas Fowell Buxton). Students could also refer to the impact of slave revolts, including the Jamaica revolt of 1831 led by Samuel Sharp, and their contribution to the abolition of slavery. Students should also be able to exemplify the contribution to the debate on slavery in the period 1760–1833 of the various abolition societies, for example the Society for the Abolition of the Slave Trade.

The fourth bullet point relates to opposition to abolition and why this opposition failed. Students should be aware of the political and economic motives for resistance, for example the fear that abolition would bring economic ruin for the planters in the West Indies. Students also need to be aware of how the abolitionists achieved support for the passing of the two acts in 1807 and 1833. These points can be illustrated by the moral debate and also the nature of compromises made by abolition supporters and MPs in Parliament. Students should also have knowledge and understanding of the main provisions of both acts.
